

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Restaurant Serving English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff.

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on [English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

- 01 Ordering for someone arriving later
- 02 Comparing lunch with an evening menu
- 03 A group order contains an unconfirmed assurance
- 04 A delayed guest changes the pace
- 05 The apology addresses the wrong issue
- 06 A receipt request after payment
- 07 Making room without taking over
- 08 A handover exposes an unfinished request

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

Ordering for someone arriving later

A diner wants three meals entered, but the third person's choice and arrival time are unconfirmed.

Roles: Server / Guest

Server: You mentioned three covers, but there are two people here. Are you ready to order?

Guest: We are, although our colleague is still traveling. Could you order his usual dish too?

Server: I don't have his usual order recorded. Do you know the dish he actually wants?

Guest: I think it's the chicken, but he sometimes chooses the vegetable tart instead of that.

Server: I can take your two confirmed choices now and leave his meal open for the moment.

Guest: That sounds sensible. We'd like two tarts, one with salad and one with potatoes, please.

Server: Which side belongs to your tart? I'll attach each choice to a separate seat number.

Guest: The salad is mine, here by the aisle. My colleague opposite me would like potatoes.

Server: Thank you. Would you prefer these sent now, or would you rather wait for him?

Guest: Send ours now. His message says he may be another twenty minutes, but that could change.

Server: I'll send the two tarts and leave the third order unentered until someone confirms it.

Guest: Perfect. We'll ask him to choose when he arrives instead of guessing what he wants.

Notice the professional language

seat number - A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

Comparing lunch with an evening menu

A guest holds an evening menu at lunch; the server explains a narrower lunch offer.

Roles: Guest / Server

Guest: This menu lists a three-course offer for thirty dollars. Can we order that for lunch?

Server: That offer belongs to the evening menu. I'm sorry we brought the wrong menu to you.

Guest: We've already chosen from it. Which of those dishes can we still have this afternoon?

Server: The soup and vegetable tart appear on both menus, but the baked dessert is evening only.

Guest: Does ordering the soup and tart here give us the evening offer's price without dessert?

Server: No, the lunch menu prices those two items separately: seven dollars and nineteen dollars, respectively.

Guest: So twenty-six dollars covers the two dishes, but no dessert or drink is included in that?

Server: Correct. There's also a twenty-two-dollar lunch set with the tart and a drink, without soup.

Guest: I want the soup, whereas my friend wants a drink. We don't need identical menu options.

Server: Then I can enter your soup and tart separately and your friend's tart as the lunch set.

Guest: Please do that, and leave these lunch menus so we can check the drinks that qualify.

Server: Here they are. I'll remove the evening menus so the two different offers don't get confused.

Notice the professional language

'Respectively' matches the first price to the first item and the second price to the second item.

'Belongs to the evening menu' explains the mismatch without suggesting the guest misread the offer.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A group order contains an unconfirmed assurance

A server checks a host's group order when one diner has a food-allergy question.

Roles: Server / Host

Server: Before I enter the shared starters, does anyone need to speak with us about an allergy?

Host: One person mentioned a nut allergy. I told them the plain-looking bread should be all right.

Server: Let's check that with the diner and kitchen lead. Appearance doesn't tell us the relevant ingredients.

Host: Could we simply leave the bread off their plate and keep the shared starters as ordered?

Server: That still wouldn't answer their questions about ingredients or cross-contact in the other dishes you've chosen.

Host: I see. I shouldn't have spoken for them. Can you ask the diner directly and privately?

Server: Yes. I'll ask what concern they want checked and pass their words to the kitchen lead.

Host: The rest of us are ready. Must every order wait while that conversation takes place today?

Server: I can clarify the separate orders, but I won't send a shared selection as suitable for everyone.

Host: Please keep the shared starters pending, then. We can decide on individual dishes after the discussion.

Server: I'll do that. Which person wanted the conversation, so I can approach them without announcing personal details?

Host: The diner beside the window asked me. I'll introduce you, and they can explain the concern themselves.

Notice the professional language

'Plain-looking' describes appearance, not ingredients.

'Speak for someone' means represent their wishes; asking directly avoids relying on a secondhand assurance.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A delayed guest changes the pace

A server and diner coordinate a meal when a third guest arrives midway through starters.

Roles: Guest / Server

Guest: Our friend has arrived now. Can their main come out at the same time as ours?

Server: Your mains have already been fired. I can ask about timing, but I can't promise that.

Guest: They haven't chosen yet. Would holding our finished plates make it easier for everyone to eat together?

Server: I'll discuss the course timing with the kitchen rather than assume finished dishes can simply wait.

Guest: What information do you need from us before you ask them to make that timing decision?

Server: First, their confirmed dish, and whether you're willing to delay your own meal if that's workable.

Guest: They've chosen the vegetable pasta. We can wait a little, but our train leaves at nine.

Server: It's eight fifteen now. I'll give the kitchen that departure constraint and check the options immediately.

Guest: Could our friend receive their pasta separately if the kitchen can't bring everything at the same time?

Server: I've checked: your mains are nearly ready. Separate service is possible, but the pasta estimate isn't confirmed.

Guest: Let's keep our existing pickup and order the pasta separately. Our friend agrees to eat a little later.

Server: I'll confirm that directly with your friend and explain that their wait hasn't yet been estimated.

Notice the professional language

'Have already been fired' places the start of preparation before the current request.

'If that's workable' makes flexibility conditional instead of assuming the kitchen can change the sequence.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

The apology addresses the wrong issue

A guest's complaint concerns a missing side, not the taste of the main dish.

Roles: Guest / Server

Guest: When I said something was wrong, you offered another main, but that's not what I meant.

Server: I'm sorry I misunderstood. Could you point out the specific part of the order that's missing?

Guest: The menu includes a side salad. The fish is fine, but the salad never arrived here.

Server: Thank you for clarifying. I'll check that missing side rather than ask the kitchen to remake the fish.

Guest: Please don't take the whole plate away. I'd like to keep eating while it's still enjoyable.

Server: Of course. Your fish stays here. I'll ask the kitchen about the included salad and its timing.

Guest: My colleague ordered an extra salad, so perhaps that caused the confusion when the plates came out.

Server: I'll check both tickets rather than assume that's the explanation. Your included side remains our responsibility.

Guest: That would help. I don't want their separately ordered salad removed or charged to my bill instead.

Server: I've checked: your included salad was missed, and the kitchen is preparing it with no extra item charge.

Guest: Thanks. That's the correction I needed. Please let the other server know the main doesn't need replacing.

Server: I'll tell them the omitted side was the issue; both main orders remain unchanged.

Notice the professional language

'Rather than' redirects the proposed action to the actual problem.

'Omitted' means left out; it does not say whether the omission was deliberate.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A receipt request after payment

A diner needs an itemized receipt after paying but doesn't want another payment processed.

Roles: Guest / Server

Guest: Could you give me something showing the individual dishes? This small slip only shows the payment total.

Server: Certainly. You're asking for an itemized receipt for the completed transaction, not to reopen the bill, correct?

Guest: That's right. I need the meal details for my records, and I already paid the full amount.

Server: I'll locate that transaction and print its itemized receipt. Do you remember the table number this evening?

Guest: We were at table sixteen, and there were two of us. We left about ten minutes ago.

Server: I have the matching completed bill here. It lists two mains, one shared dessert, and two drinks.

Guest: That sounds right. Please don't add a second payment or change the amounts on the original bill.

Server: No additional payment is being requested. This is another receipt for the transaction that is already complete.

Guest: Could the receipt show the restaurant name and date as well as those individual items, please?

Server: Yes, those appear at the top of this itemized receipt. Please check that the meal details match.

Guest: They do. I confused the payment slip with the itemized version, so thank you for explaining that.

Server: You're welcome. Here is the itemized copy to keep with your payment slip.

Notice the professional language

'For the completed transaction' distinguishes a receipt copy from a new purchase.

'Itemized' means broken into individual entries, not necessarily divided among different payers.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

Making room without taking over

A crowded table needs space for mains while diners keep a shared starter.

Roles: Server / Guest

Server: Your mains are nearly ready, and the table is crowded. May we make a little space together?

Guest: Yes, but we're still sharing the starter. Please don't take it away just to make room.

Server: I'll leave that dish. Which of these smaller items have you finished using for this course?

Guest: The empty butter dish and bread basket can go, but we still need the side plates here.

Server: Thank you. I can remove those two items and bring the water jug closer to this edge.

Guest: Please check with my companion before moving their glass. They have arranged things so they're easy to reach.

Server: Certainly. I'll ask them directly, and nothing needs to move just because I've suggested a different position.

Guest: Could we also have one clean serving spoon? The original one fell, and we haven't used it since.

Server: I'll bring a replacement spoon. I'll let the runner know the starter is staying while mains arrive.

Guest: That's the arrangement we'd like. We aren't asking for another starter or changing our main course orders.

Server: Understood. One replacement spoon, the two empty items cleared, and the shared starter left on the table.

Guest: There's enough space now. Thank you for checking what we'd finished.

Notice the professional language

'Finished using' focuses on the item, not whether the guest has finished the meal.

'The starter is staying' is a concise service instruction; it doesn't mean another starter was ordered.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A handover exposes an unfinished request

An incoming server checks whether a takeaway-box request has actually been completed.

Roles: Incoming server / Outgoing server

Incoming server: Before we finish the handover, which tables are still waiting for something?

Outgoing server: Table twenty has paid, and table twenty-two is waiting for dessert. Everything else should be fairly straightforward.

Incoming server: Table twenty asked me about a takeaway box. Was that request completed before they settled their bill?

Outgoing server: I asked a runner for a box, but I haven't seen it reach the table yet.

Incoming server: Then payment is complete, but the box request remains unconfirmed. I'll check with the guests directly now.

Outgoing server: Thank you. Table twenty-two ordered one tart and two spoons; the dessert station has accepted that order.

Incoming server: Do they know the estimated wait, or is that another detail I need to obtain for them?

Outgoing server: They were given an estimate of five minutes just now. Please pass on any change from the station.

Incoming server: I'll take the box check and the dessert follow-up. Have you already finished the napkin restock here?

Outgoing server: Yes, the napkins are complete. The clean spoon delivery is still pending, so don't mark that task done.

Incoming server: Understood. I'll own the two table requests and ask the dish team about the missing spoons afterward.

Outgoing server: I'll introduce you before leaving, so they know whom to ask.

Notice the professional language

estimated wait - An approximate time before an item is expected, not a guarantee.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Confirming seats and order details

SHARED CASE

Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest at seat two: confirm that no onions applies to your salad, not the pasta. Seat three needs another minute.

Useful expressions

Was ___ for your ___ or for ___?

I have ___ for seat ___, with ___.

You're still deciding on ___; is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Before I send table twelve's order, could I check who requested no onions? I have mushroom pasta for seat one and a salad with dressing on the side for seat two. Seat three is still deciding. I'll attach the onion request to the correct dish and read those details back.

Second round

Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Explaining menu choices and prices

SHARED CASE

The fictional lunch set costs \$24 and includes a main and dessert. Steak adds a \$5 supplement. The a la carte steak is \$27 without dessert. Both steak options include potatoes. Explain the \$29 set steak option versus \$27 steak alone.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare complete menu options without hiding an extra charge. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest: you like steak but are unsure whether you want dessert. Ask for both complete prices.

Useful expressions

___ costs ___ and includes ___.

The supplement brings the total to ___.

___ includes ___, whereas ___ does not.

Cover this until after your first attempt

The steak set would be twenty-nine dollars: the twenty-four-dollar set price plus a five-dollar supplement. It includes dessert and potatoes. The a la carte steak is twenty-seven dollars with potatoes but no dessert. If you don't want dessert, the separate steak costs less; the set includes the extra course.

Second round

The guest says 'So both are twenty-four dollars?' Correct the total without restarting the whole menu explanation.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Receiving an allergy question

SHARED CASE

A guest at table 6 reports a sesame allergy and asks about a bun. The server has an old menu description, not current ingredient or cross-contact information. The kitchen lead is available to discuss the question before any order is sent.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a stated allergy and identify the information still needed. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest: you have reported a sesame allergy and want reliable information before selecting food.

Useful expressions

You mentioned an allergy to ____.

I haven't confirmed ____ for this item.

The kitchen lead can check ____ before you decide.

Cover this until after your first attempt

Thank you for telling me about your sesame allergy. The old menu description doesn't establish the current bun's ingredients or how it is handled. I can't confirm suitability from that description. I'll ask the kitchen lead to check your specific question before sending a food order, and bring back the verified information.

Second round

The guest says they ate the bun last month. Explain why the current item still needs checking.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Coordinating courses and delays

SHARED CASE

Table 14 finished starters. Their mains were fired at 7:20. At 7:30 the kitchen estimates another eight minutes; one dish is still being prepared. The guests need to leave at 7:50. State the estimate and offer a timing discussion without guaranteeing completion.

Role A | Responding professional

Report an actual delay while keeping approximate timing clear. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest: your departure time is fixed at 7:50. Ask whether eight minutes is a promise.

Useful expressions

As of ___, the estimate is another ___.

___ is ready; ___ is still being prepared.

Does that leave enough time for ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

We asked the kitchen to start your mains at seven twenty. One dish is still being prepared, and the current estimate is another eight minutes. I know you need to leave at seven fifty. That is an estimate, not a guaranteed serving time; would you like me to discuss your timing with the kitchen?

Second round

The estimate changes to twelve more minutes. Report the change and ask whether the guest wants available alternatives discussed.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Correcting a dish without blame

SHARED CASE

Table 3 ordered vegetable pasta but received mushroom risotto. The ticket confirms pasta. The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. The server may offer that replacement, but any bill adjustment needs the shift lead's review.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a specific mismatch and agree what happens next. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest: you ordered pasta and have limited patience for a ten-minute wait. Ask about the bill.

Useful expressions

You ordered ___, but we brought ___.

The replacement would take approximately ___.

Would you like ___, or would you prefer to speak with ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'm sorry we brought risotto when your order was vegetable pasta. I've checked the ticket, and it does show pasta. The kitchen can remake it, with an estimated ten-minute wait. Would that work for you? If you want to discuss a bill adjustment, I'll ask our shift lead rather than promise one myself.

Second round

The guest declines a replacement. Accept the choice and bring the shift lead into the bill discussion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Explaining and splitting a bill

SHARED CASE

Three diners have a fictional \$72 total with all listed charges included. They request 'three ways': this could mean equal payments or separate checks by item. The restaurant supports either before payment. Ask which they mean; equal shares would be \$24.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish equal payment shares from item-based bills. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest: clarify that 'three ways' means individual items; two guests shared one dessert.

Useful expressions

Would you like equal shares or ___?

This charge refers to ___ on the bill.

Before payment, could we confirm ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

When you say three ways, would you like three equal payments or separate checks for each person's items? The total shown is seventy-two dollars, including the listed charges. Equal payments would be twenty-four dollars each. If you prefer separate checks, I'll confirm who had each item before any payment is taken.

Second round

The guests disagree over the shared dessert. Ask for their agreed allocation rather than choose for them.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Agreeing on clearing and shared service

SHARED CASE

At table 2, one diner's plate is empty but the shared vegetable dish still has food. The diner is using the plate for another portion. Ask what can be cleared; offer extra sharing plates without removing active items.

Role A | Responding professional

Get permission to clear specific items without rushing the table. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Guest: your empty plate is still needed for vegetables, but the empty glasses can go.

Useful expressions

Are you finished with ___?

Shall I leave ___ for now?

May I reach across to remove ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

May I clear the empty glasses, or are you still using them? I'll leave your plate and the shared vegetables because you're taking another portion. Would an extra sharing plate help? I can bring one and then check which serving items you're finished with, without interrupting the rest of your meal.

Second round

The guest says 'take those' while pointing between glasses and plates. Clarify the items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Handing over a live section

SHARED CASE

At 8:00 Maya takes over tables 4 and 5. Table 4's mains are served, and dessert has not been ordered. Table 5 has an open check and a pending duplicate-coffee query being reviewed by the shift lead. Ask Maya to accept both follow-ups.

Role A | Responding professional

Name each table's status and get the incoming server's acknowledgment. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Incoming server: accept both tables and repeat which bill question remains unresolved.

Useful expressions

Table ___ has ___; ___ is still open.

Please check ___ before ___.

Can you take over ___ while I ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Maya, table four has its mains and hasn't ordered dessert. Table five's check is still open because the shift lead is reviewing a possible duplicate coffee charge. Please check on four's dessert preference and get the lead's decision before presenting five's bill again. Can you take those two follow-ups while I finish the station restock?

Second round

The shift lead has not decided about the coffee charge. Keep the question open while accepting follow-up.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Whose onion request?

Table 12: the three-cover order in the case.

- 01 • Server:** I caught the request for no onions, but which dish does that apply to?
- 02 • Guest:** My salad, please. My friend wants the mushroom pasta exactly as it normally comes.
- 03 • Server:** Thank you. Are you also the person who asked for dressing on the side?
- 04 • Guest:** Yes, I want the dressing separately, not removed from the order altogether, please.
- 05 • Server:** Then seat two has the salad, no onions, with dressing in a separate serving.
- 06 • Guest:** That's right. The person beside the window hasn't chosen a main course yet.
- 07 • Server:** I have seat one down for pasta and seat three as still deciding.
- 08 • Guest:** Could you give seat three another minute before you send the main course order?
- 09 • Server:** Certainly. I'll wait here a moment; would another menu help with the choice?
- 10 • Guest:** Yes, please. The third menu is underneath our coats, and another would be useful.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Moving chairs after ordering

Two diners have swapped seats before a runner arrives.

01 • Runner: I have the vegetable tart for seat one. Did anyone change seats after ordering?

02 • Guest: Yes, we swapped so my colleague could sit farther away from the speaker.

03 • Runner: Thanks for telling me. Who ordered the tart with the small green salad?

04 • Guest: I did, and I'm now sitting beside the aisle rather than the window.

05 • Runner: Then this plate belongs here. The pasta is for your colleague by the window?

06 • Guest: Correct. Neither of us changed the dishes; we only moved to different chairs.

07 • Runner: I'll tell your server about the move so the dessert orders reach you correctly.

08 • Guest: Please do. We're ordering different desserts and would rather not switch plates again.

09 • Runner: I'll identify the dishes as I bring them, as well as checking the updated seats.

10 • Guest: That works. You can put the tart here, with the salad beside it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A phrase lost in the noise

A server checks an incomplete order during a busy lunch.

01 • Server: I'm sorry, the music covered your last words. Was that soup and a sandwich?

02 • Guest: Soup instead of a sandwich, actually. I don't need both items for lunch.

03 • Server: Thank you for correcting that. Which soup would you like from today's two choices?

04 • Guest: The tomato soup, please, with the bread that appears beside it on the menu.

05 • Server: I have one tomato soup with bread. Would you like the small or large portion?

06 • Guest: The small one. I only have time for a light lunch before my meeting.

07 • Server: Let me read that back: one small tomato soup with bread, and no sandwich.

08 • Guest: Exactly. Could you also check whether my colleague's drink has already been ordered?

09 • Server: Your colleague asked me for sparkling water earlier, and that order is already in.

10 • Guest: Great. Then the soup is the only item you still need to add.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Confirming seats and order details

Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest at seat two: confirm that no onions applies to your salad, not the pasta. Seat three needs another minute.

Second round: Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

Scenario 2 | Two similar side dishes

A table orders one baked potato and one portion of mashed potatoes. The server hears 'without butter' but cannot identify the dish.

Role A: Server: clarify the dish and repeat both side orders.

Role B: Guest: the baked potato is yours and you prefer it without butter; the mashed potatoes belong to your companion.

Possible opening: Was the no-butter request for the baked potato or the mashed potatoes?

Success checks

- Obtain the dish name.
- Attach the preference to the baked potato only.
- Read back both orders without inventing an ingredient claim.

Add a complication: The guest points instead of naming the dish, and both diners are holding menus.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The five-dollar misunderstanding

The lunch menu in the case is open between server and guest.

01 • Guest: The steak says five dollars underneath it. Is that really the price of the meal?

02 • Server: That's the supplement to the twenty-four-dollar set menu, making the steak set twenty-nine dollars.

03 • Guest: Does that include the potatoes, or would those be another item on my bill?

04 • Server: Potatoes are included. The set also includes one dessert from the choices listed below.

05 • Guest: I don't usually have dessert. Is there a price for just the steak and potatoes?

06 • Server: Yes, the a la carte steak is twenty-seven dollars, with potatoes but without dessert.

07 • Guest: Then the extra two dollars on the set gets me one of those desserts?

08 • Server: For these two options, yes. The difference is two dollars and the included dessert.

09 • Guest: I'll choose the separate steak. Please don't add the set menu to my order.

10 • Server: Certainly. One a la carte steak with potatoes, priced at twenty-seven dollars before any applicable charges.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A starter is not a side

A diner compares a side salad with a larger starter salad.

01 • Guest: Could I have the starter salad with my main instead of the little side salad?

02 • Server: You can order the starter salad separately. It's larger and has its own menu price.

03 • Guest: I thought every salad was included when the main says it comes with a salad.

04 • Server: That refers to the side salad listed with the main, not the starter selection above.

05 • Guest: How much more would the starter cost, and could you remove the included side?

06 • Server: The starter is eight dollars. Removing the included side doesn't reduce this main's listed price.

07 • Guest: In that case, I'll keep the included salad and skip the larger starter today.

08 • Server: Of course. Would you like the main and its side brought together as listed?

09 • Guest: Yes, together. I was looking for a bigger salad, but the extra cost changes my choice.

10 • Server: I'll keep the standard main with its included side and no separately charged starter.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Today's special has a price

A server describes a special before the diner commits.

01 • Server: Today's special is a roasted vegetable tart with a green salad, priced at nineteen dollars.

02 • Guest: Is it part of the lunch set, or did you mean a separate special?

03 • Server: It's a separate item today. The lunch set choices are printed in this other section.

04 • Guest: Thank you. Does the special come with a drink, or is that priced separately?

05 • Server: Drinks are separate. The nineteen dollars covers the tart and its accompanying green salad.

06 • Guest: Could you compare that with the twenty-two-dollar lunch set before I choose between them?

07 • Server: The set includes a main and a drink, but its main choices don't include the tart.

08 • Guest: I'd rather have the tart and tap water, so please order the special for me.

09 • Server: Certainly. That's the nineteen-dollar special with tap water, and no set menu on the order.

10 • Guest: Exactly. Thanks for giving me the price before I had to ask about it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining menu choices and prices

The fictional lunch set costs \$24 and includes a main and dessert. Steak adds a \$5 supplement. The a la carte steak is \$27 without dessert. Both steak options include potatoes. Explain the \$29 set steak option versus \$27 steak alone.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: you like steak but are unsure whether you want dessert. Ask for both complete prices.

Second round: The guest says 'So both are twenty-four dollars?' Correct the total without restarting the whole menu explanation.

Scenario 2 | A shared starter charge

A fictional menu lists a soup starter at \$7 and a sharing platter at \$18. The platter description says 'serves two'; \$18 is the whole platter price.

Role A: Server: explain price and suggested serving size.

Role B: Guest: ask whether 'serves two' means \$18 per person; choose the platter once clarified.

Possible opening: Is the sharing platter eighteen dollars each?

Success checks

- State that \$18 covers one platter.
- Separate serving size from a per-person price.
- Confirm whether the guest wants additional soup.

Add a complication: The guest also assumes two soups are included, but neither is included.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The bun description is incomplete

Table 6: the sesame question from the case.

- 01 • Guest:** I have a sesame allergy. Your bun description doesn't mention seeds; can I eat it?
- 02 • Server:** Thank you for telling me. That description doesn't confirm the current ingredients or handling arrangements.
- 03 • Guest:** I've had buns here before, although I don't remember whether this is the same one.
- 04 • Server:** I can't confirm this bun from your earlier visit. I'll ask the kitchen lead for today's ingredient list.
- 05 • Guest:** Please ask about sesame in the bread itself, not only the seeds on top.
- 06 • Server:** I'll pass on both that ingredient question and your concern about possible cross-contact.
- 07 • Guest:** Should I choose the burger now, or wait until those details have been checked?
- 08 • Server:** Let's leave the food order unsent while we get the information you need to decide.
- 09 • Guest:** All right. Please bring the kitchen lead if the answer needs a longer explanation.
- 10 • Server:** I will ask them to speak with you; your sesame question is still unresolved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An omission isn't an allergy label

A diner requests no coriander for taste, and the server checks meaning.

01 • Server: You asked for no coriander on the salad. Is that a preference or an allergy?

02 • Guest: It's a dietary preference. I don't enjoy coriander, but I'm not reporting an allergy.

03 • Server: Thank you. I'll record a preference to omit the coriander garnish, subject to the kitchen's confirmation.

04 • Guest: Does that mean you can remove every trace of coriander from the whole dish?

05 • Server: Not necessarily. The dressing may already contain it, and I haven't checked that recipe yet.

06 • Guest: Then could you check the dressing too? I'd choose another salad if it's mixed in.

07 • Server: Certainly. Is the concern the coriander flavor throughout the dish rather than the garnish alone?

08 • Guest: Exactly. I wouldn't want you to change the garnish while leaving the same flavor underneath.

09 • Server: I'll ask that specific question before entering the salad, then explain the available choices.

10 • Guest: Thanks. We can keep my order open while my friend orders their own meal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Repeating the guest's actual words

A server speaks to the kitchen lead about a pending order.

01 • Server: Table nine reports a milk allergy and asks whether today's soup contains any milk ingredients.

02 • Kitchen lead: Have you sent the soup order already, or are they waiting for our answer?

03 • Server: They're waiting. I said I'd check the actual recipe and handling information before they choose.

04 • Kitchen lead: Good. Was their question only about a cream garnish, or the whole soup preparation?

05 • Server: The whole preparation. They specifically asked whether removing the garnish would settle the issue.

06 • Kitchen lead: I need the current recipe and allergen information; removing a garnish wouldn't settle that.

07 • Server: I'll keep the soup pending. Would you speak directly with them after checking those details?

08 • Kitchen lead: Yes. Tell them I'm gathering the current information and will come to their table.

09 • Server: I'll do that, without describing the soup as suitable before your discussion with the guest.

10 • Kitchen lead: Thank you. Please give me the table number again so I don't approach the wrong party.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Receiving an allergy question

A guest at table 6 reports a sesame allergy and asks about a bun. The server has an old menu description, not current ingredient or cross-contact information. The kitchen lead is available to discuss the question before any order is sent.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: you have reported a sesame allergy and want reliable information before selecting food.

Second round: The guest says they ate the bun last month. Explain why the current item still needs checking.

Scenario 2 | A changed sauce supplier

A diner reports a peanut allergy. A colleague remembers an earlier sauce specification, but this week's sauce comes from a different supplier.

Role A: Server: explain the limit of the old information and request a current check.

Role B: Kitchen lead: you can review the new product information and speak to the diner; suitability is not yet established.

Possible opening: Does last week's ingredient sheet apply to this week's sauce?

Success checks

- Identify the supplier mismatch.
- Keep the food choice pending.
- Relay the allergy rather than infer a preference.

Add a complication: The old sheet has the same product name but a different supplier.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Eight more minutes

Table 14 at 7:30, following the timing case.

01 • Server: I've checked your mains. One dish is still being prepared; the estimate is another eight minutes.

02 • Guest: We ordered a while ago. Does that mean eight minutes from when you first sent it?

03 • Server: No, eight more minutes from this update. Your mains were fired at seven twenty.

04 • Guest: We need to leave at seven fifty. Is the eight-minute serving time definite now?

05 • Server: It's the kitchen's current estimate, not a guarantee. I'll make your departure time clear to them.

06 • Guest: Please do. We need time to eat, not simply have the plates arrive before we leave.

07 • Server: Understood. Would you prefer to wait on that estimate, or ask about another available option?

08 • Guest: Let's wait for now, but please tell us promptly if the kitchen's estimate changes again.

09 • Server: I will. I'll bring the bill when requested, so payment doesn't add avoidable delay.

10 • Guest: Please bring it with the mains. Let us know if the wait gets longer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Holding dessert for a call

A diner requests a pause between the main and dessert.

01 • Guest: Could you hold our desserts? My colleague has stepped outside to take a work call.

02 • Server: Of course. Do you mean delay both desserts, or cancel one of them altogether?

03 • Guest: Delay both, please. We still want them, but we'd like to eat them together.

04 • Server: I'll ask the dessert station to hold the order if it hasn't already been prepared.

05 • Guest: Can you check that now? I don't want something sitting here while they're outside.

06 • Server: The station confirms the desserts haven't been prepared, so both are now on hold.

07 • Guest: Thank you. Should I wave when we're ready, or place the dessert order again?

08 • Server: Just let me know you're ready. The original order remains; there's no need to duplicate it.

09 • Guest: They're coming back now, but we'd like five more minutes before you request the desserts.

10 • Server: I'll leave the hold in place until you tell me to send that request.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

One plate isn't the whole table

A runner checks an incomplete pickup at the pass.

01 • Runner: I see three plates for table eight, but their ticket shows four main courses.

02 • Expediter: The fourth dish is finishing. Please don't describe the entire table as ready yet.

03 • Runner: Should I take these three now, or wait for the complete pickup from you?

04 • Expediter: Wait for my call on this table. I need to coordinate the final dish with the cook.

05 • Runner: The server is asking what to tell the guests. Do you have a current estimate?

06 • Expediter: About three more minutes, but I'll update you if that changes during the pickup.

07 • Runner: I'll tell the server the table isn't complete and the current estimate is three minutes.

08 • Expediter: Thanks. Please keep table eight separate from the two plates beside it for table eighteen.

09 • Runner: These three stay here while we wait for the fourth; table eighteen's two plates stay separate.

10 • Expediter: That's right. I'll call the full table number when each pickup is ready to leave.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Coordinating courses and delays

Table 14 finished starters. Their mains were fired at 7:20. At 7:30 the kitchen estimates another eight minutes; one dish is still being prepared. The guests need to leave at 7:50. State the estimate and offer a timing discussion without guaranteeing completion.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: your departure time is fixed at 7:50. Ask whether eight minutes is a promise.

Second round: The estimate changes to twelve more minutes. Report the change and ask whether the guest wants available alternatives discussed.

Scenario 2 | Starter or main?

A guest orders soup and pasta and says 'together.' The restaurant normally serves starters before mains; neither item has been sent.

Role A: Server: check whether both dishes should arrive at once.

Role B: Guest: you want soup as your main while your companion eats pasta, not two courses for yourself.

Possible opening: When you say together, are these two mains for different people?

Success checks

- Clarify diners and timing.
- Correct the seat assignment.
- Read back simultaneous service as a request, not a guaranteed time.

Add a complication: The order screen currently assigns both dishes to one seat.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Risotto instead of pasta

Table 3 receives the wrong main, as in the case.

01 • Guest: This looks like mushroom risotto. I ordered vegetable pasta when you took our main courses.

02 • Server: You're right; the ticket shows vegetable pasta. I'm sorry we brought the wrong dish.

03 • Guest: Can you replace it, and how long would I be waiting for the correct meal?

04 • Server: The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. Would that work for you?

05 • Guest: My friend is already eating. Could you remove my dish from the bill as well?

06 • Server: I can arrange the replacement; a bill adjustment needs our shift lead's review.

07 • Guest: Please ask them, but go ahead with the pasta. I'd still like to eat.

08 • Server: I'll send the remake request and ask the lead to speak with you about the charge.

09 • Guest: Thank you. Please tell them I've accepted the replacement, not agreed about the final bill.

10 • Server: I will make that distinction clear, and check back when your pasta reaches the table.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A check-back gets a real answer

A guest says a meal is not what they expected.

01 • Server: How is the tart? Is there anything about your order that needs our attention?

02 • Guest: It's much smaller than I expected. I thought it would fill the whole plate.

03 • Server: I understand. The menu doesn't give a size, so I can see why expectations differed.

04 • Guest: I'm not saying it's badly made. I just need something more substantial for lunch.

05 • Server: Would you like to see the available side dishes and prices before deciding what to add?

06 • Guest: Yes, but please don't order anything automatically. I want to know the total first.

07 • Server: The potato side is four dollars, and the green salad is five dollars today.

08 • Guest: The potatoes sound better. Please add one portion, provided that price is the full item price.

09 • Server: Four dollars is the listed side price. I'll add one portion and confirm its expected wait.

10 • Guest: Thanks. That addresses my concern; I wanted a clearer choice, not a different tart.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Two plates crossed at pickup

A runner discovers that two complete orders were assigned to wrong tables.

01 • Runner: I checked the pickup tickets and think I brought table seven's tart to table eleven.

02 • Server: Table eleven has just questioned it. Their ticket shows a salad, not a tart.

03 • Runner: I'll tell the expediter exactly which dish and table were involved in the mix-up.

04 • Server: Please do. We need replacement instructions, not simply a guess about switching the plates back.

05 • Runner: Agreed. The tart has already reached the guest, so I'll explain that fact clearly.

06 • Server: I'll speak to table eleven and acknowledge the wrong dish while you check the replacement.

07 • Runner: The expediter confirms a fresh salad is being prepared, with a five-minute estimated wait.

08 • Server: I'll offer that estimate to the guest and ask whether the replacement still suits them.

09 • Runner: Do you need me to speak with table seven as well about their missing dish?

10 • Server: Yes, please explain that we're checking their order; don't claim it's already on its way.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Correcting a dish without blame

Table 3 ordered vegetable pasta but received mushroom risotto. The ticket confirms pasta. The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. The server may offer that replacement, but any bill adjustment needs the shift lead's review.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: you ordered pasta and have limited patience for a ten-minute wait. Ask about the bill.

Second round: The guest declines a replacement. Accept the choice and bring the shift lead into the bill discussion.

Scenario 2 | The sauce arrived on the food

A guest requested sauce separately but receives sauce over the dish. The ticket confirms the separate-sauce request. The kitchen offers a remake in eight minutes; no price adjustment is approved.

Role A: Server: apologize, describe the remake option, and check the guest's choice.

Role B: Guest: you want the correct dish but need to know the wait.

Possible opening: I asked for the sauce on the side; this plate has it on top.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the ticketed request.
- Distinguish an available option from a started remake.
- Confirm the guest's choice before reporting it to the kitchen.

Add a complication: The guest asks whether the remake is already being prepared, but you haven't requested it yet.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Three ways can mean two things

The \$72 bill in the case is unpaid.

01 • Server: Before arranging a split payment, would you like equal shares or separate checks by item?

02 • Guest: Actually, we'd each like to pay for our own food rather than divide everything equally.

03 • Server: Certainly. Equal thirds would be twenty-four dollars, but I'll prepare separate checks by item instead.

04 • Guest: Thank you. I had the pasta and water, and my colleague here had the tart.

05 • Server: Who should have the shared dessert on their check, or would you like it divided?

06 • Guest: Put the whole dessert on mine, please. I offered to treat them to that part.

07 • Server: I'll allocate the dessert to your check, and confirm the remaining drink with the third diner.

08 • Guest: That drink belongs to them. Can we see the individual bills before making any payments?

09 • Server: Yes. I'll bring the three checks back for review before asking you to pay.

10 • Guest: Great. We meant three separate bills, so I'm glad you checked before assuming equal amounts.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A charge appears twice

A guest queries a duplicate drink on an unpaid bill.

01 • Guest: The bill shows two lemonades, but I only ordered one during the whole meal.

02 • Server: Let me check the order record and the two entries before we process your payment.

03 • Guest: One line says lemonade and the other says the same thing with a later time.

04 • Server: I can see both entries. Did anyone else at your table order a second one?

05 • Guest: No. My companion had water, and there was no refill or second glass for me.

06 • Server: Thank you. The shift lead has confirmed the duplicate entry and approved its removal.

07 • Guest: Could you bring the revised bill so I can see which amount actually changed?

08 • Server: Certainly. This corrected version has one lemonade; the duplicate line is no longer charged.

09 • Guest: That matches what we had. Is this now the version we'll use for payment?

10 • Server: Yes, this revised bill is the one to review and pay, not the earlier copy.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An optional extra is not required

A server explains a fictional bill with a labeled service charge.

01 • Guest: This bill has a service charge and another blank line. Are both amounts required?

02 • Server: The printed service charge is included in this total; the blank line is for an optional tip.

03 • Guest: So leaving that optional line blank doesn't remove the service charge already printed above it?

04 • Server: Correct. They are different entries. The total here already includes the restaurant's stated service charge.

05 • Guest: Can you tell me how that charge is distributed among the people working tonight?

06 • Server: I don't have a verified explanation of distribution. Our shift lead can answer that question.

07 • Guest: Please ask them. I want to understand the charge before deciding about an extra tip.

08 • Server: I'll bring them over, and leave the payment unprocessed while you discuss that question.

09 • Guest: Thank you. Please don't infer any optional tip amount from what we paid last time.

10 • Server: Of course. Any optional extra is your choice, not an assumption from a previous visit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining and splitting a bill

Three diners have a fictional \$72 total with all listed charges included. They request 'three ways': this could mean equal payments or separate checks by item. The restaurant supports either before payment. Ask which they mean; equal shares would be \$24.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: clarify that 'three ways' means individual items; two guests shared one dessert.

Second round: The guests disagree over the shared dessert. Ask for their agreed allocation rather than choose for them.

Scenario 2 | Two payers, four diners

Four diners agree that one payer covers all food and another covers all drinks. The bill is unpaid and can be split by item.

Role A: Server: clarify the two groups of charges.

Role B: Guest: you pay for food, including the shared dessert; your companion covers drinks.

Possible opening: Would you like the food on one check and the drinks on the other?

Success checks

- Resolve the conflicting descriptions.
- Place dessert with food.
- Confirm the grouping before payment.

Add a complication: The guest initially says 'half each' but then explains the unequal item grouping.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An empty plate still has a purpose

Table 2 has a shared vegetable dish, as in the case.

01 • Server: May I clear this plate, or are you still using it for the shared vegetables?

02 • Guest: Please leave it. I was just about to take another portion from that serving dish.

03 • Server: Of course. Are these two empty glasses finished with, or would you prefer them left too?

04 • Guest: You can take the glasses. We'd like to keep the water jug and our water glasses.

05 • Server: I'll clear only the two empty juice glasses, leaving the jug and all plates here.

06 • Guest: Thank you. Could we have another sharing plate for the person at the end?

07 • Server: Certainly. Would one small plate be enough, or does anyone else need one as well?

08 • Guest: Just one, please. The rest of us already have plates for the shared food.

09 • Server: Here you are. I'll leave the serving dish until you tell me you're finished with it.

10 • Guest: That's helpful. We're taking our time, but we don't need all those empty glasses.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Reaching across a conversation

A server needs permission to retrieve a dish near a guest.

01 • Server: Excuse me, may I reach across for that empty dish, or should I come around?

02 • Guest: Please come around. There's an open laptop here, and I don't want anything moved across it.

03 • Server: Certainly. I'll approach from the other side so your laptop can stay where it is.

04 • Guest: Thank you. The dish is finished, but the cup beside it still has tea inside.

05 • Server: I'll take just the dish. Would you like the cup moved closer to you?

06 • Guest: No, it's fine there. I'm waiting for the tea to cool before I drink it.

07 • Server: Understood. I'll leave the cup and its saucer exactly where you've placed them.

08 • Guest: Could you remove the unused menu too? We have everything we want for now.

09 • Server: Yes, I'll take that menu from this side without disturbing the laptop or drink.

10 • Guest: That gives us more room. Thanks for checking which things we still needed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Enough settings for a shared dessert

Two diners want one dessert but separate spoons and plates.

01 • Guest: We're sharing one dessert. Could you bring enough tableware so we don't have to pass it around?

02 • Server: Certainly. Would you like two small plates and a spoon for each of you?

03 • Guest: Yes, please. The dessert can stay in the center while we divide it ourselves.

04 • Server: I'll bring two dessert place settings and leave room for the shared dish.

05 • Guest: Please leave our coffee cups as well, even though one looks almost empty now.

06 • Server: Of course. Are you finished with the bread basket, or is that still in use?

07 • Guest: The basket can go, but my friend is keeping the last piece on their side plate.

08 • Server: I'll remove the basket only. Your side plates and coffee cups will stay here.

09 • Guest: That sounds right. There should be plenty of space once the basket is gone.

10 • Server: Here are the dessert plates and spoons; I'll set the shared dish between you.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Agreeing on clearing and shared service

At table 2, one diner's plate is empty but the shared vegetable dish still has food. The diner is using the plate for another portion. Ask what can be cleared; offer extra sharing plates without removing active items.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: your empty plate is still needed for vegetables, but the empty glasses can go.

Second round: The guest says 'take those' while pointing between glasses and plates. Clarify the items.

Scenario 2 | A guest steps away

A guest leaves the table briefly. Their companion says the main plate is still in use, but the starter plate is finished.

Role A: Server: confirm which plate can be cleared.

Role B: Companion: identify the small starter plate and ask that the main stay.

Possible opening: Which plate has your companion finished with?

Success checks

- Identify the small starter plate.
- Leave the main in place.
- Avoid inferring that the absent guest has finished.

Add a complication: Both plates contain scraps, so appearance alone does not resolve the question.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two tables, two different loose ends

The 8:00 handover in the case.

01 • Outgoing server: Can you take tables four and five? Four's mains are served, but they haven't ordered dessert.

02 • Maya: Yes. I'll check whether they want dessert once they've had time to finish their mains.

03 • Outgoing server: Five has an open check; the shift lead is reviewing a possible duplicate coffee charge.

04 • Maya: So I shouldn't present their current bill again as though the question were already resolved?

05 • Outgoing server: Correct. Please get the lead's decision first, then explain the confirmed outcome to the table.

06 • Maya: I'll take that follow-up too. Have either table's guests been told that I'm replacing you?

07 • Outgoing server: Not yet. I'll introduce you before I leave the section to restock the service station.

08 • Maya: Good. Is there any other food order waiting to be sent for those tables?

09 • Outgoing server: No pending food orders. The dessert preference and the coffee-charge review are the remaining tasks.

10 • Maya: Understood. I'll handle those two checks, and you can finish the station restock.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A break handover includes the limit

A server asks a colleague to cover one table during a short break.

01 • Server: I'm taking a ten-minute break. Could you cover table six without taking over my whole section?

02 • Cover server: Yes, table six only. What have they received, and is any part of their order pending?

03 • Server: Their mains have arrived. They asked for more water, but I haven't brought it yet.

04 • Cover server: I'll bring the water and check whether they need anything else while you're away.

05 • Server: Thank you. Their dessert order hasn't been discussed, so please don't assume they're finished.

06 • Cover server: Understood. If they want dessert, I'll take the order and tell you when you return.

07 • Server: The bill is also open, with no query or adjustment requested at this point.

08 • Cover server: If they ask to pay during your break, I'll handle that under our usual arrangement.

09 • Server: Please let me know afterward whether the check is still open or has been settled.

10 • Cover server: I will. Water is the immediate request, and I'll report any order or payment change.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Restocking without an assumption

Two servers divide closing support work while one table remains seated.

01 • Server: I'll do the napkin side work while you cover the remaining table. Have the clean cutlery trays arrived?

02 • Colleague: One tray has arrived, but the second is still with the dish team.

03 • Server: Then I won't mark the whole station restock complete yet. Which supplies are actually missing?

04 • Colleague: Small spoons and folded napkins. The forks and dinner knives are already stocked in their compartments.

05 • Server: I'll finish the napkins, and you can ask about the small spoons after checking the table.

06 • Colleague: That works. The table hasn't paid, so I need to stay available for their bill request.

07 • Server: I'll leave the service station accessible while they're here.

08 • Colleague: Thanks. Could you tell me when the napkins are done so I don't repeat that task?

09 • Server: They are stocked now. Only the spoon tray remains outstanding from the list we discussed.

10 • Colleague: I'll follow up with the dish team once the table's immediate request has been handled.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Handing over a live section

At 8:00 Maya takes over tables 4 and 5. Table 4's mains are served, and dessert has not been ordered. Table 5 has an open check and a pending duplicate-coffee query being reviewed by the shift lead. Ask Maya to accept both follow-ups.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Incoming server: accept both tables and repeat which bill question remains unresolved.

Second round: The shift lead has not decided about the coffee charge. Keep the question open while accepting follow-up.

Scenario 2 | A move between sections

Table 9 moves to table 19 for a quieter seat. The same unpaid order must follow the diners. The incoming server has not been briefed.

Role A: Outgoing server: explain the move and current order.

Role B: Incoming server: accept the diners at 19; their drinks have arrived and mains are pending.

Possible opening: The guests at nineteen moved from nine; they haven't placed a second order.

Success checks

- Identify old and new tables.
- Avoid duplicating the order.
- Confirm who tells the runner and follows up on the mains.

Add a complication: A runner still sees table 9 on the food ticket.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/waiters-and-waitresses.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-3031.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Restaurant Serving English

Professional audience: Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff

Scope: All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

Dialogue 01: Ordering for someone arriving later

Original fictional setting: A diner wants three meals entered, but the third person's choice and arrival time are unconfirmed.

Professional roles: Server / Guest

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Server: You mentioned three covers, but there are two people here. Are you ready to order?

Guest: We are, although our colleague is still traveling. Could you order his usual dish too?

Server: I don't have his usual order recorded. Do you know the dish he actually wants?

Guest: I think it's the chicken, but he sometimes chooses the vegetable tart instead of that.

Server: I can take your two confirmed choices now and leave his meal open for the moment.

Guest: That sounds sensible. We'd like two tarts, one with salad and one with potatoes, please.

Server: Which side belongs to your tart? I'll attach each choice to a separate seat number.

Guest: The salad is mine, here by the aisle. My colleague opposite me would like potatoes.

Server: Thank you. Would you prefer these sent now, or would you rather wait for him?

Guest: Send ours now. His message says he may be another twenty minutes, but that could change.

Server: I'll send the two tarts and leave the third order unentered until someone confirms it.

Guest: Perfect. We'll ask him to choose when he arrives instead of guessing what he wants.

Vocabulary in this exchange: seat number: A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
 2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
 3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
 4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
 5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.
- Use voice replies when available. If I prefer selections, offer four plausible spoken replies and explain my choice before continuing. Do not require written compositions.

END PROMPT

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Restaurant Serving English

Professional audience: Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff

Scope: All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

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Guest: Perfect. We'll ask him to choose when he arrives instead of guessing what he wants.

Vocabulary in this exchange: seat number: A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT